did my thing. I slammed everything. I was free, not nervous, and started going after every ball – even those from Wasim Akram and Waqar Younis.

Naturally, my slam-bam hitting at the nets didn't go unnoticed.

The next day, the two Ws made some sort of pact, which was based around skinning me. Both of them upped their pace by a few notches. But I didn't feel it and I didn't care – I hit them all around anyway. The faster they came at me, the harder I hit back. I wasn't trying to prove anything. I was just trying to play my natural game. I had no apprehensions or any pressure.

Then, after the nets came the rumour every batsman waits for the locker-room mill to churn out – that he might open the innings. Soon, the confirmation came in. Wasim bhai, before he headed back to Pakistan to deal with a family emergency, had told Saeed Anwar – he was to lead the team in his absence – to make sure I batted. I will always be thankful to him for believing in me.

But opening the innings for Pakistan? It was as unbelievable as it was unlikely. Outwardly, I was a bit hesitant ('Listen, I've come as a bowler, I don't think I can do this'). Of course, secretly, I welcomed it. Cricket is about adventure and risks. And international cricket is the greatest adventure of all.

The scenario built up somewhat like this. I never batted in the first match, my ODI debut, against Kenya. It wasn't a bad game and I had a decent spell, starting proceedings in the 17th or 18th over, and grabbing a quick wicket too. I didn't get to bat during our innings. However, I didn't have much to worry about in that match. My teammates backed me and I'd done well in the West Indies. Kenya, with all due respect, was not the strongest opposition in the world at the time.

Before the second match, all I'd been told was, 'Listen, you may be opening tomorrow, or going in one down.'

When we all turned in for the night, I couldn't get my wits together. But anyway, I slept, or tried to sleep. I was thoroughly fidgety and very anxious. I remember when I thought it was time to wake up, I went to the washroom, showered and shaved and woke up my roommate, Shadab Kabir.

He said, 'What's wrong, Lala?'

I said, 'Time for the game, man. Let's go!'

Shadab responded, 'Lala, have you gone mad? It's two-thirty in the morning! Get some sleep!'

I was embarrassed. Tired of waiting, I tried to sleep again. When I woke up, I apologized to Shadab for having woken him up earlier. Then we started talking.

'I had a dream last night,' I told him.

'How could you? You didn't sleep!' he said, jokingly.

'I'm serious. I had a dream that I was slamming Jayasuriya and Muralitharan and Dharmasena for sixes,' I said. 'Big, huge sixes.'

'Let's pray it happens, brother,' said Shadab. 'Now, let's get some breakfast.'

The dream and how it came true – Jayasuriya went for 94 off his 10 overs, and Muralitharan went for 73 – is something Shadab talks to me about even today. He remembers it because he was the only one I'd shared that moment with. In cricket, roommates end up sharing memories together. That was our moment. It was a dream that God willed. Its coming true was also something He willed, and it has remained with me as a precious memory since then.